

long this balance at this interest rate would take to pay off in full. If we can put a man on the moon, and the credit card companies can, at the drop of a hat, pull thousands of FICO scores, computed by a complicated algorithm, the calculation of a pay off timeframe should not be a problem.

But they do not want you to know. And they keep changing the interest rates.

Send in the Clowns

Their pals in Washington aren't going to do anything about the industry and all the complaints either. I hear the saying, "Power corrupts and absolute power corrupts absolutely." It seems to fit.

Let's return to the interview.

INTERVIEWER: How profitable is the credit card industry?

EDWARD YINGLING: The credit card business is profitable.

(Let me interrupt for one brief second. That is the weakest response to an interview question that I have ever heard.)

INTERVIEWER: I thought it was the most profitable sector in the banking industry.

EDWARD YINGLING: I think it depends on how you define sectors....

(Another interruption. When we start saying things like, "It depends on how you define..." it usually means we are avoiding the subject.)

INTERVIEWER: MBNA's profits last year, one and a half times that of McDonald's.

EDWARD YINGLING: Well, McDonald's didn't do too well last year.

(Sorry, I have to interject again. This interview took place in September 2004. I didn't look up profit numbers for McDonald's, but doesn't McDonald's do well every year? The credit card banks do better than McDonald's. Admit it.)